

MEDITERRANEAN DIET FOOD LIST

EAT

Vegetables

- Leafy greens (spinach, kale, arugula, Swiss chard, collard greens)
- Tomatoes, cucumbers, bell peppers
- Zucchini, eggplant, broccoli, cauliflower
- Onions, mushrooms, carrots
- Artichokes, asparagus, fennel, okra
- Beets, green beans, sweet potatoes

Fruits

- Berries, apples, oranges, grapes
- Figs, dates, pears, peaches
- Pomegranates, cherries
- Apricots, plums, melons, tangerines
- Mediterranean citrus (lemons, mandarins)

Whole Grains

- Oats, quinoa, bulgur
- Brown rice, barley
- Whole-grain bread & pasta
- Farro, couscous, millet, sorghum
- Freekeh (cracked wheat grain)

Healthy Fats

- Extra virgin olive oil (main fat)
- Avocado
- Olives
- Tahini (sesame paste)
- Olive tapenade

Legumes & Beans

- Lentils, chickpeas, black beans
- Kidney beans, white beans, peas
- Fava beans (broad beans)
- Cannellini beans
- Split peas

Nuts & Seeds

- Almonds, walnuts, pistachios
- Sunflower seeds, chia, flax
- Sesame seeds, pine nuts, pumpkin seeds
- Hazelnuts, cashews

Herbs & Spices

- Basil, oregano, rosemary
- Garlic, mint, cumin, turmeric
- Thyme, parsley, dill
- Paprika, coriander, za'atar
- Saffron, sumac

Seafood (2-4 times/week)

- Salmon, sardines, mackerel
- Tuna, trout
- Shrimp, prawns, mussels
- Anchovies, calamari, clams
- Sea bass, sea bream (Mediterranean staples)

Dairy (Moderate)

- Greek yogurt
- Feta, mozzarella, ricotta
- Kefir

LIMIT

Poultry

- Chicken breast, thighs, wings
- Turkey breast, ground turkey
- Grilled or baked preferred
- Avoid fried or breaded versions

Eggs

- Whole eggs
- Omelets and scrambled eggs
- Egg-based dishes (quiche, frittata)
- Consume in moderation (2-4/week)

Higher-Fat Dairy

- Full-fat cheese (cheddar, gouda, brie)
- Cream cheese
- Sour cream
- Heavy cream
- Whole milk
- Butter (only tiny amounts recommended)

Red Meat

- Beef, lamb, goat, veal
- Steak, burgers, meatballs
- Limit to small portions 1-2 times per month
- Choose lean cuts when possible

Refined Grains (Use sparingly)

- White rice
- White pasta
- White bread
- Regular couscous
- Instant noodles
- Refined flour tortillas

Starchy Foods (Moderation)

- Potatoes (fried or mashed with cream)
- Potato chips (limit strictly)
- Corn-based processed foods

Sweets & Desserts

- Cakes, cupcakes
- Ice cream
- Cookies, brownies
- Pastries, donuts
- Muffins
- Sweetened yogurts
- Limit added sugar overall

Alcohol

- Red wine optional but limited (1 glass/day or less)
- Beer or cocktails only occasionally
- Avoid binge drinking

Packaged Snacks (Limit quantity)

- Crackers
- Pretzels
- Granola bars (with added sugar)
- Lightly processed nut mixes

AVOID

Processed Foods

- Fast food (burgers, fries, fried chicken)
- Frozen meals with additives
- Microwave dinners
- Instant ramen

Highly Processed Meats

- Bacon
- Sausage
- Pepperoni, salami
- Hot dogs
- Deli meats (ham, bologna, turkey slices)

Refined & Added Sugars

- Sugary drinks (soda, energy drinks)
- Artificial fruit juices
- Candy & chocolate bars
- Breakfast cereals with added sugar
- Syrups (corn syrup, pancake syrup)
- Sweetened coffee drinks

Unhealthy Fats & Oils

- Margarine
- Vegetable shortening
- Hydrogenated oils
- Industrial seed oils (corn, soybean, canola)
- Deep-fried foods

Ultra-Refined Carbs

- White flour pastries
- Donuts
- Croissants
- White bread with added sugar
- Commercial bakery items

Processed Snacks

- Chips (potato, tortilla)
- Cheese puffs
- Candy-coated nuts
- Sweetened popcorn

Fast-Food Desserts

- Milkshakes
- Sundaes
- Fried desserts (churros, funnel cake)

Artificial & Chemical Additives

- Artificial sweeteners (aspartame, sucralose)
- Artificial colorings
- Preservatives (BHA, BHT)
- Flavor enhancers (MSG, artificial flavors)

Excessive Salt Foods

- Cup noodles
- Canned soups with high sodium
- Salted crackers, salted nuts
- Pretzels